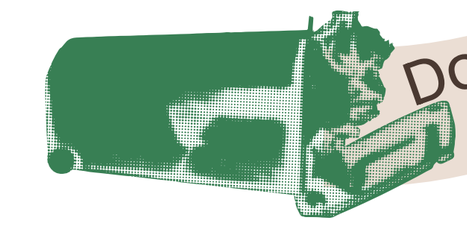
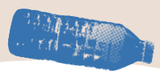
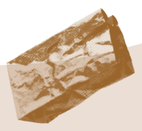
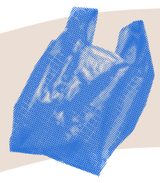
Down in the Dumps

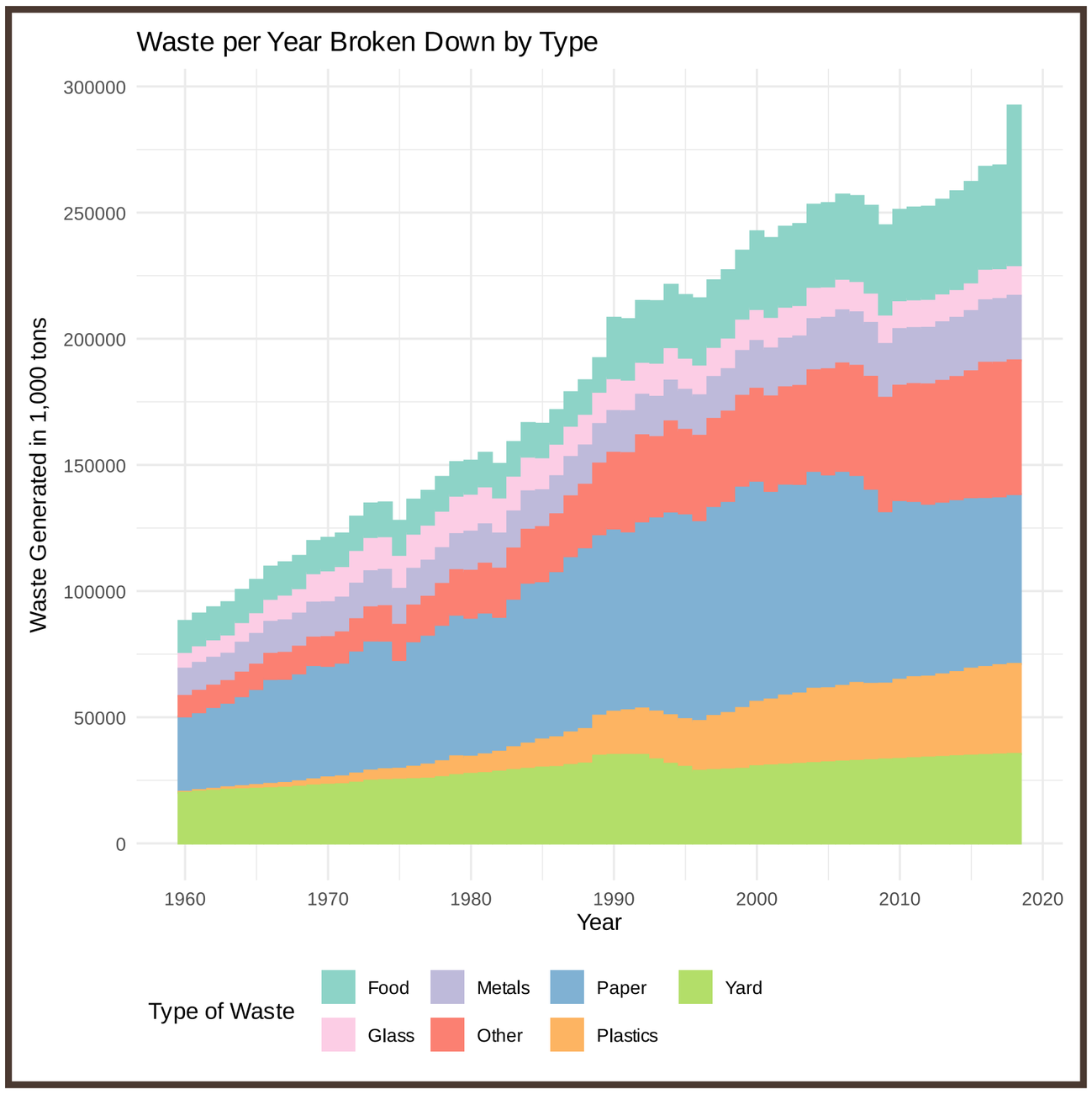
a look at changes in waste generation in the US from 1960-2018

Elyse Freeman - DSA 7040

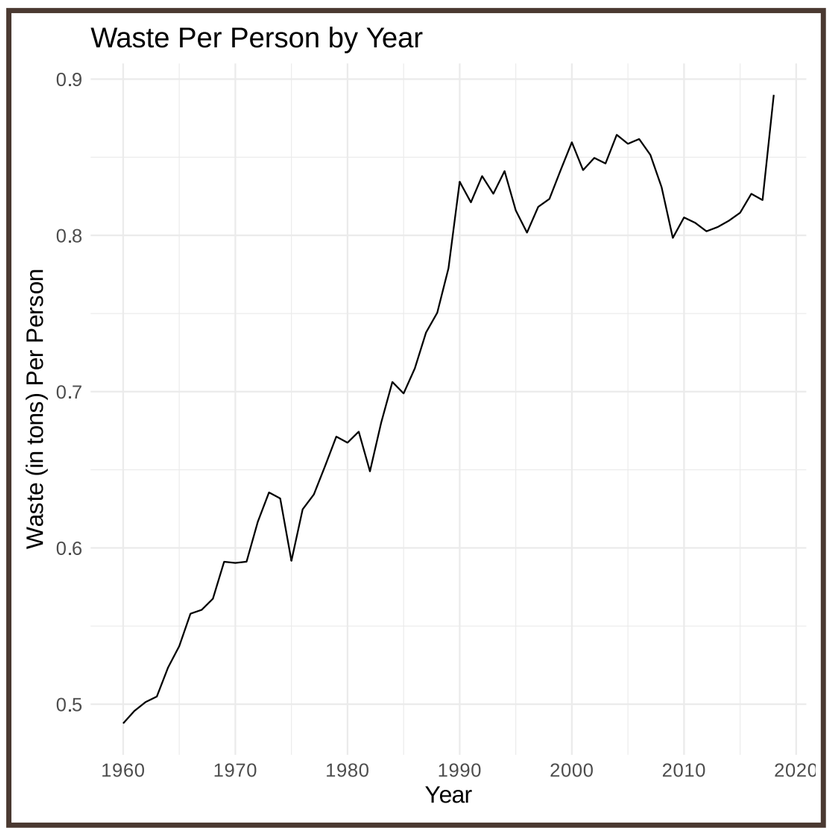


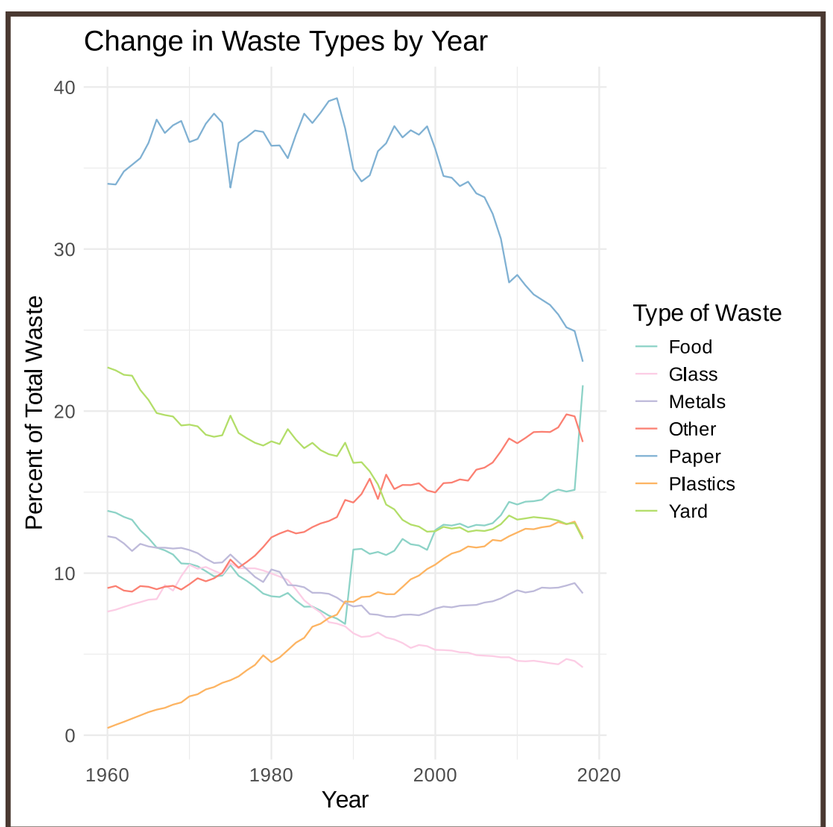



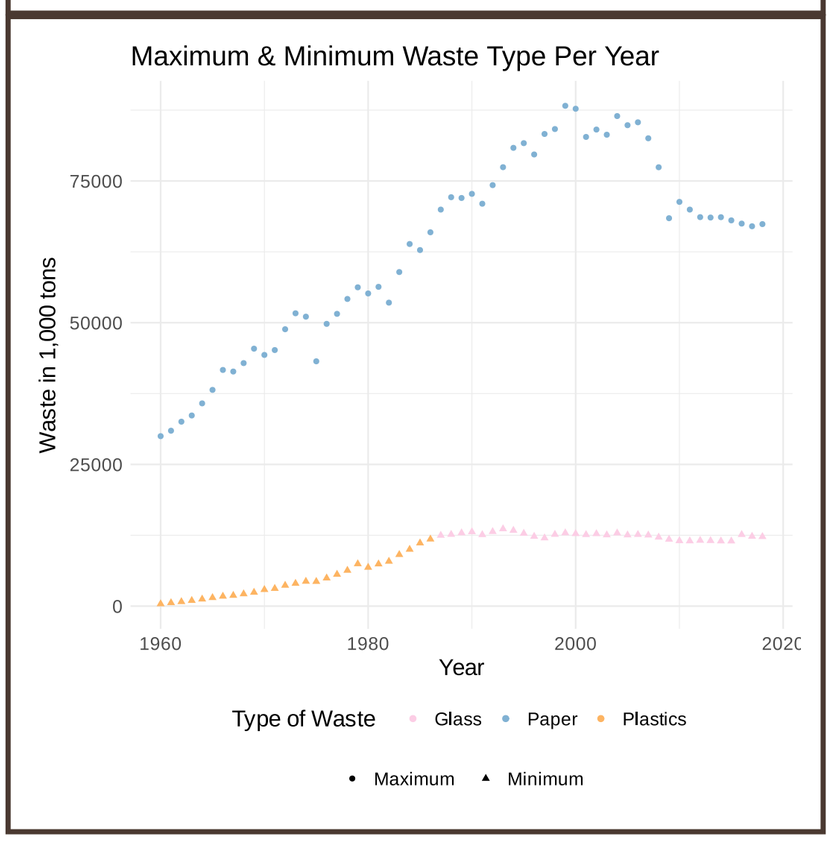


As population has increased in the US, so has waste generated per person. An average person generated **0.488 tons or 975 pounds** of trash in 1960 compared to **0.889 tons or 1780 pounds** in 2018.



The US gained **1.48 million people** and **2.04 million tons of waste** between 1960 and 2018. With waste amounts growing faster than population, waste per person is close to reaching 1 ton or 2,000 pounds per person.





Has the makeup of waste generated changed in 60 years?



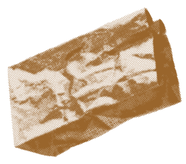
Plastic began to increase in popularity in the 1980's. Plastic is light-weight and cheap to produce. Plastic recycling is not perfect, so most plastic will end up in a landfill where it will take hundreds of years to breakdown.

Yard waste has seen a decline in generation since 1960. This is most likely because of an increase in alternate disposal methods such as composting.



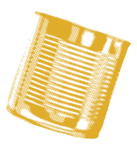
Food waste measurement standards were changed in 2017 which led to a spike in 2018. The collected data was expanded to include food waste that was disposed of outside of traditional landfilling, composting, and combustion.

The Other category which includes rubber, leather, textiles, and wood has been steadily increasing since 1960. This is possibly related to an increase in fast fashion and “disposable” clothing becoming more popular.



Paper has been the top waste type generated since 1960, but its percentage share of total waste has been declining since 2000. A shift to paper-free as well as physical newspapers losing popularity are factors in this decline.

Glass generation was growing between 1960 and 1980, before a decline to 2018. It is the least prevalent waste type in generation. This could be because of an increase of alternatives, like plastic, being used instead of glass.



The amount of metal generated has doubled since 1960 whereas total waste generated has tripled leading to little change in the presence of metals.

Waste generation has increased with population growth. New materials and life style changes impact the waste we make. As we look to the future, consider the waste you make and where it will end up.

*Using data from the EPA Historical Facts & Figures